

The Australian Government has committed \$33.8 million over 15 years (2014-2029) to help farmers gain improved access to safe and effective agricultural and veterinary (agvet) chemicals, and assist them in producing food for Australia and the world.

The Department of Agriculture, Fisheries and Forestry is working closely with the Australian Pesticides and Veterinary Medicines Authority (APVMA), grower groups, rural Research and Development Corporations (RDCs) and the chemical industry to deliver this initiative.

The program has a range of activities:

- supporting collaboration between growers, producers and the chemical industry on the access needs of Australian agriculture
- establishing an official Australian crop grouping list and associated APVMA guidelines (released by the APVMA on 11 January 2019, accessible at [Representative crops and extrapolation principles for risk assessment and data waivers](#))
- migrating some uses authorised under APVMA-issued permits to product labels
- an assistance grants program to help fund the generation of sufficient data to support applications to the APVMA
- improving the prioritisation of grants to the needs of Australian agriculture.

In addition to the work taking place under the new funding, the government is also committed to [reforming agvet chemicals regulation](#) to improve the efficiency and effectiveness of the system and increase access to chemicals.

The department has progressed several initiatives with the new funding to improve access to agvet chemicals, as listed below.

From 2018, the department has hosted collaborative forums annually to develop a priority list of industry-nominated agvet chemical needs to inform each round of the [Assistance Grants – Access to Industry Priority Uses of Agvet Chemicals program](#). The collaborative forum expanded the role of participants to produce a list more closely aligned with farmers' agvet chemical needs. Participants include RDCs, the National Farmers' Federation, Animal Health Australia, Plant Health Australia and the Australian federal and state and territory governments. The forum is also observed by the APVMA, Animal Medicines Australia, CropLife Australia, Veterinary Manufacturers and Distributors Association and international minor use experts.

The next collaborative forum will be held in 2027 to support grant round 12.

The APVMA has developed an [official Australian list of crop groupings](#) and associated guidelines.

The official crop grouping list reduces regulatory costs for producers to gain access to more uses of agricultural chemicals.

Data generated for crops within a crop grouping can be applied to the whole crop with little or no additional data needed. In practice, where a registration/permit has been gained for representative

crops, automatic extension or approval would be allowed to all other crops within the group (and possibly across groups) without the need for additional data or review.

More information is available through the [APVMA website](#).

The department provided a grant of \$240 000 (GST not applicable) to the [APVMA](#) to examine permits currently issued to peak industry bodies (involving uses in crops and livestock species) and determine suitable candidate permits to migrate to product labels (registration), and liaise with the holders to facilitate migration of permits to registrations.

The duration for a permit granted by the APVMA can vary from one season to up to 10 years. As permits have a limited duration, permit holders must periodically submit applications to the APVMA to renew permits. This may or may not require submission of new data. This renewal activity can consume a significant amount of resources from stakeholders’ existing access to chemicals programs, as well as the APVMA, as it has to assess these renewal applications. Migrating permit uses to product labels eliminates the need for some existing permits and provides wider access to use.

For more information on this project, please [contact the APVMA](#).

The department developed the Assistance Grants – Access to Industry Priority Uses of Agvet Chemicals program to support the generation of sufficient data for applications to the APVMA for agvet chemical uses identified as a priority by the collaborative forum. The next grant round will commence in the 2027/28 financial year, providing \$3.5 million in grants.

The number and value of grants awarded in each round is recorded below:

	2015-16	2016-17	2017-18	2018-19	2019-20	2020-21	2021-22	2022-23	2013-24	2024-25	2025-26
Grants awarded	49	51	26	23	22	21	16	18	13	11	20
Total grants value (\$ million)	1.61	2.5	1.76	2	2	2	2	2	2	2	3.5

Access to safe and effective agvet chemicals is important to Australian agricultural industries, the community and the environment.

Farmers use agvet chemicals to protect crops and animals from pests and diseases, and treat infections. However, Australian farmers sometimes have difficulty accessing agvet chemical uses available to overseas competitors.

The small size of the Australian market can make the costs involved with registering an agvet chemical in Australia uncommercial. This is particularly the case for treating pests and diseases in specialty crops and livestock species. Larger industries face a similar problem when managing uncommon or emerging pests and diseases. These agvet chemical access issues are often referred to as the ‘minor use’ issue.

The program will improve access to agvet chemicals and increase the number of uses available to producers. To successfully deliver enduring improvements to access to agvet chemicals the program will:

- improve the ability of producers to effectively share their needs and priorities for uses of agvet chemicals between themselves, grower groups, chemical companies and government.
- improve producers' access to a broader range of Australian approved uses for those agvet chemicals already in the Australian market.
- increase the number of approved uses that chemical companies choose to bring to the Australian market when introducing a new agvet chemical to Australia.

The department continues to consult with stakeholders on other measures that could deliver these improvements.

The government currently contributes funding to the RDCs to:

- generate data to support applications for APVMA minor use permits
- generate data to support applications through APVMA for a new label use.

The government also contributes to the APVMA's Agricultural and Veterinary Chemicals Minor Use program (~\$135 000 annually).

An initial \$8 million was announced in the 2014-15 budget under the improved access program. A further \$6.3 million, \$2.4 million and \$9 million were committed in the 2018-19, 2020-21 and 2021-22 budgets respectively to continue the program through to 2024-25. Funding was further extended from 2024-25 to 2028-29 with an additional \$8.1 million in funding.

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Source: <https://www.agriculture.gov.au/agriculture-land/farm-food-drought/ag-vet-chemicals/improved-access-agvet-chemicals>